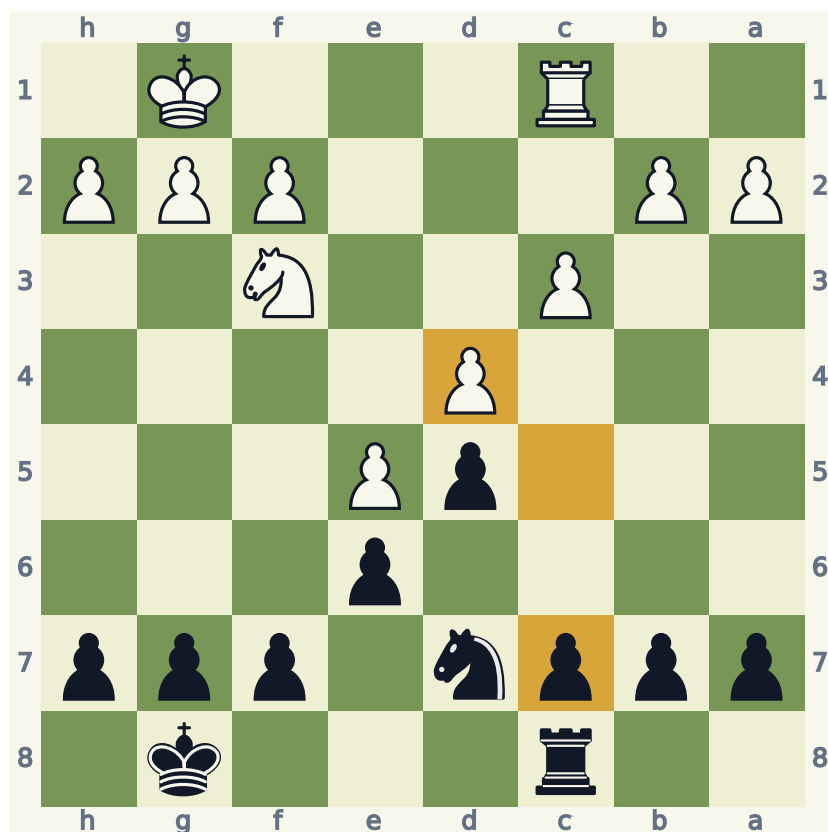


Pawn breaks

Prepare the move that changes the position.

A pawn break creates contact with enemy pawns so that files, diagonals or squares can open. Its purpose is the resulting position, not the pawn push itself. Work backward: name the line you want to open, identify the relevant pawn contact, and prepare the pieces that will use it.

MODEL A | BLACK TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- White's e5-pawn is supported by d4.
- The black c7-pawn can challenge that base with ...c5.
- Nd7 can recapture on c5 after dxc5.

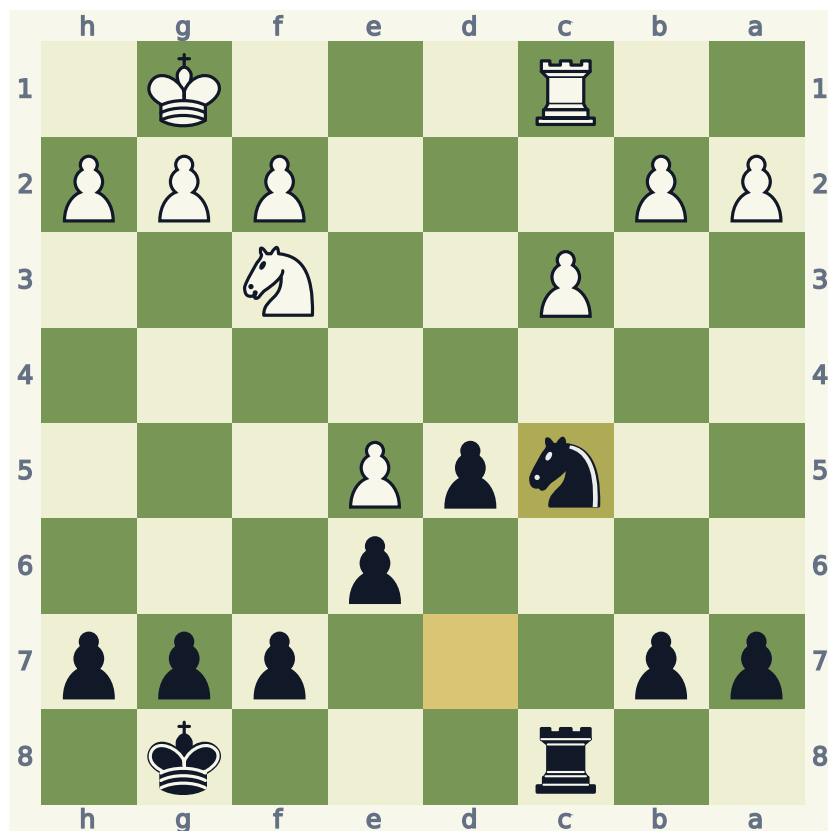
REMEMBER

- Name the target pawn.
- Prepare the recapture and the open line.
- Judge the position after the exchanges.

Follow the logic

1... c5 2. dxc5 Nxc5

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



...c5

Attack the base of White's central chain. The move asks White to choose a structural response.

dxc5

This illustrative capture removes White's d4-pawn. Other replies must also be considered; the capture is not forced.

...Nxc5

Black develops the knight by recapturing and reduces White's central support. The break has improved a piece, not merely exchanged pawns.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

White can maintain the tension and add support to d4. Black must calculate d5-related tactics and ensure that opening the c-file will not favor White's rook more.

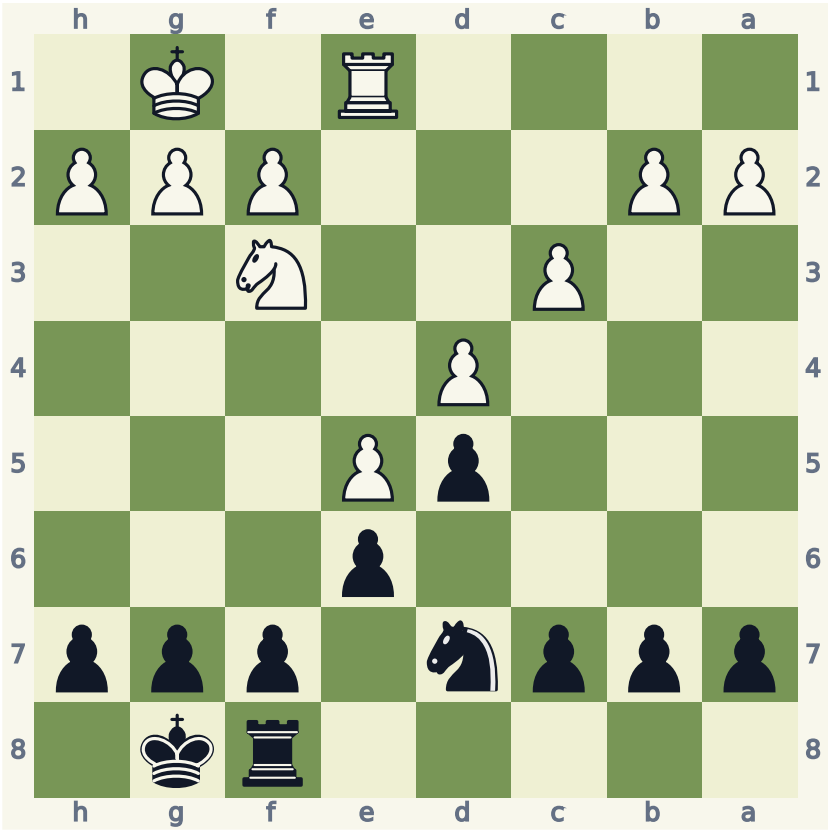
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

An unprepared break can create a weak pawn or open a line for the opponent. Count attackers and recaptures, and inspect all checks and intermediate moves in the resulting position.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | BLACK TO MOVE



- 1. Which break attacks the head of White's chain?
- 2. What piece gains activity after the sample exchange?
- 3. What new risk has Black accepted by moving the f-pawn?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If the knight could not recapture on f6, what would you calculate next?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 5rk1/pppn1ppp/4p3/3pP3/3P4/2P2N2/PP3PPP/4R1K1 b - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. ...f6 attacks e5, the chain's advanced pawn. It is a different method from ...c5 against d4. Both breaks aim to reduce White's central grip, but they open different files and diagonals.
2. After exf6 ...Nxf6, the d7-knight reaches f6 and White's e5-pawn disappears. Black has converted a pawn exchange into development and access to e4 and g4.
3. The f-pawn has left the king shelter. In this queenless example the risk is limited, but in a fuller middlegame checks, sacrifices and an opened f-file could make the same break unsafe.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1... f6 2. exf6 Nxf6

Changed feature: Check the other legal recaptures and the cost of each. A break justified by a favorable knight recapture may fail when only a weakening pawn recapture is available.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

In your next analysis, find both sides' main pawn break before suggesting a piece move. Write the intended recapture beside each break.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 03, 06, 14. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.